CHAPTER 2: SATAN'S STRATEGIES TO KEEP BELIEVERS FROM SERVING GOD

DEVICE #2 – Convince believers that serving God will cost too much.

Many people know what God wants them to do, but they are afraid of what might happen if they obey Him. They fear rejection, criticism, suffering, loss of friends, loss of opportunities, or other hardships.

The Bible tells us that many of the Jewish rulers believed in Jesus, but would not openly confess Him because they feared being put out of the synagogue (John 12:42). Their fear of people kept them from fully following Christ.

Satan still uses this same device today. He whispers, "If you obey God, life will become harder." He wants believers to focus on the possible cost of obedience instead of the value of obedience.

QUESTIONS

[42] Nevertheless, many even of the authorities believed in him, but for fear of the Pharisees they did not confess it. John 12:42 (ESV)

Why were these rulers afraid to openly follow Jesus?

What are some things that Christians today may fear losing because of their faith?

REMEDY #1 – No amount of trouble can take away the treasures God gives to His people.

A believer may lose many things in this life. He may lose money, opportunities, possessions, comfort, or the approval of others. But no trouble can take away the believer's greatest treasures.

No one can take away God's love, God's forgiveness, peace with God, the presence of the Holy Spirit, or the promise of eternal life.

When believers remember that their treasures are safely kept by Christ, they can continue serving God even when difficulties come.

QUESTIONS

[12] "...for I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard until that Day what has been entrusted to me." 2 Timothy 1:12 (ESV)

What are some things that people fear losing?

What treasures has Christ promised that cannot be taken away?

How should this truth affect the way we live?

REMEDY #2 – Remember the example of faithful believers who endured hardship.

Throughout Scripture, God's people faced opposition and suffering.

Nehemiah continued rebuilding Jerusalem despite threats from his enemies. Daniel remained faithful even when it put his life in danger. The apostles continued preaching Christ even when they faced imprisonment.

Their examples teach us that difficulties are not a reason to stop serving God.

QUESTIONS

Which Bible character in your opinion best demonstrates courage in obeying God?

Why is it helpful to study the lives of faithful believers?

What can we learn from their example?

REMEDY #3 – The troubles of obedience are temporary, but the consequences of neglecting God are far greater.

Following Christ may sometimes bring suffering. People may reject us, criticize us, or misunderstand us. But refusing to obey God carries a far greater danger. Temporary difficulties only last for a little while. Separation from God lasts forever.